
The Family Meeting Agenda

A fill-in-the-blank worksheet for the conversation every family dreads,
and how to make it go well.

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RIGGINS STRATEGIC SOLUTIONS

“The goal of the first meeting isn't to get a ‘yes.’ It's to get to the next meeting.”

From The Senior Transition by Ryan Riggins, Chapter 7.

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Before you start

The goal of the first family meeting is not to make a final decision. It is to agree on a process for making one.

This worksheet follows Chapter 7 of *The Senior Transition*. Print one copy for the sibling pre-meeting and one for each person at the table. Fill in the blanks as you go. Nothing on these pages has to be decided today except one small next step.

THE FOUR STEPS

- 1. The pre-meeting.** Get your siblings on the same page first.
- 2. Set the agenda and the tone.** Send it ahead of time.
- 3. Run the meeting like a pro.** Parents speak first.
- 4. Close with one concrete next step.** A research task, not a decision.

Step 1: The sibling pre-meeting

Do this by phone, Zoom or coffee, without your parents. This is where you have the disagreement, if you need to. Your goal is to agree on the problem, not the solution.

Who's in

*Every sibling, and any spouse
who will be in the room*

Our shared problem

*One sentence everyone agrees is
true. Example: "Mom's safety in
her house is a growing concern,
and we are all worried about
her."*

Options we will put on the table to explore

*Not decide. Everyone's preferred
answer goes here as an option
to research.*

Roles

Facilitator

*The calmest sibling. Keeps the
agenda, does not argue a side.*

Note-taker

*Writes down what Mom and
Dad say, word for word if
possible.*

Who needs a reminder

*Who is most likely to get
emotional, and who will gently
pull them back to the script?*

Step 2: The invitation

How you ask is everything. This is not an intervention. Say it in your own words, but keep the key phrases: *together as a family, on the same page, supporting you the way you want, and listen to your thoughts.*

WHAT TO SAY

“Mom, Dad, we were all hoping we could set aside an hour next Sunday to talk together as a family. There's nothing wrong, it's not an emergency. It's just that we all think it would be smart to be on the same page about the future. We want to make sure we're all supporting you in the way you want to be supported. We'd like to just listen to your thoughts and make sure we understand your priorities.”

The meeting

Date and time

One hour, and say so.

Place

*Their living room is usually best.
Not a restaurant, not one of the
kids' houses.*

Purpose (read this out loud to open)

*To listen to each other and start
a conversation about how we
can best support each other in
the years to come.*

Send the next page to everyone ahead of time. People don't fear the conversation. They fear not knowing what's in it.

Family Meeting Agenda

1. Opening (5 min)

Acknowledging our love and respect for Mom and Dad. The facilitator reads the purpose and says something from the heart.

Notes

2. Mom and Dad's perspective (20 min)

What's working well right now? What are some of the challenges? **Then listen.** Don't interrupt, don't correct, don't offer solutions. Ask, "Can you tell me more about that?"

Notes

3. Our perspective (15 min)

Sharing our hopes and concerns for the family's future, using "I" statements.

Notes

4. Brainstorming (15 min)

What are all the possible options for the future? No bad ideas. Write every one down.

Notes

5. Next step (5 min)

Agreeing on one small, concrete action to take next.

Notes

Step 3: In the room

“I” statements, not “you” statements

An “I” statement claims your own feeling. A “you” statement casts blame.

INSTEAD OF THIS, SAY THIS

Don't say: “You're not eating right. Your fridge is always empty.”

Do say: “I feel worried when I think about you not having regular, hot meals. It would give me peace of mind to know you're eating well.”

Don't say: “You need to stop driving at night. It's not safe.”

Do say: “I get a knot in my stomach when I know you're driving home in the dark, because I'm scared of something happening to you.”

My “I” statement

Write yours before the meeting.

The brainstorm list

Staying in the house. A condo. Moving in with one of the kids. A granny pod in the backyard. Assisted living. A live-in caregiver. Write it all down. This is not the time to debate.

Every idea

Step 4: One concrete next step

A meeting without a clear action item is just a therapy session.

The next step should be a research task, not a decision. Low stakes, focused on gathering information.

GOOD NEXT STEPS

Two of us spend the next two weeks gathering basic information on options A and B: brochures and cost estimates. We review them at our next chat in a month.

For the next month, we hire a landscaping service to take the yard work off Dad's plate, and see how it feels.

We have a home safety assessment done and get a report of suggestions. We don't have to act on any of them.

NEXT STEPS THAT BACKFIRE

"We're touring the assisted living place Saturday." Too fast, too big a leap.

"Dad, you need to call a realtor this week." A command, not a collaboration.

"We'll talk again when someone has more information." Too vague, no one owns it.

Our one next step

Who owns it

By when

Our next family check-in

Date and time

Close by thanking your parents for their courage and openness. **The goal of the first meeting isn't to get a 'yes.' It's to get to the next meeting.**

WHEN YOU WANT A SECOND SET OF EYES

Every tool from the book, chapter by chapter: rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/book

Talk it through with Ryan on a 30-minute call: rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/book/call